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RocJocks: Hoops legend Al Butler

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Perhaps the greatest high school basketball player ever from our region, Al Butler averaged 32 points per game as a senior at East High in 1957. The second-leading scorer that year averaged 22 points.

That's just one indicator of how dominant he was. Butler was Rochester's first four-time All-City first-team basketball selection. In 1996, a panel of experts voted him Section V's all-time best player. He was a near-unanimous selection.

Butler went on to a stellar collegiate career at Niagara University, where he averaged 22.8 points per game. He ranks second on the school's all-time average scoring list behind only Calvin Murphy (33.1 points per game).

Butler was drafted by the Boston Celtics in 1961, but had a hard time cracking a starting lineup that featured three other guards who would end up in the basketball Hall of Fame: Bob Cousy, Sam Jones, and K.C. Jones.

A trade sent Butler to the New York Knicks, and he took advantage of the opportunity to get more playing time, scoring a career high 14.7 points per game.



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He played three seasons with the Knicks before being dealt to the Baltimore Bullets for the 1964-65 season. He finished his four-year NBA career with Baltimore. In 234 career games, he averaged 9.8 points.

Butler retired from the NBA to return to Niagara and earn his degree in counseling. He was a guidance counselor at Monroe Community College for 28 years before retiring in 1997.

Butler died of cancer in 2000, just days after his 62nd birthday.

Each week, we recognize a great sports figure from the Rochester area. See the complete list at [RocDocs.com/Athletes](https://www.rocdocs.com/Athletes).

Several readers wrote in to nominate Butler, including Joseph Shanahan and Dave Stokes.

Whose name should we add next? Send an email to slahman@gannett.com with your suggestions.

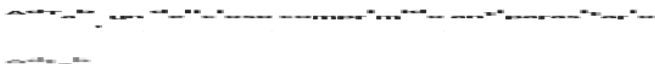
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